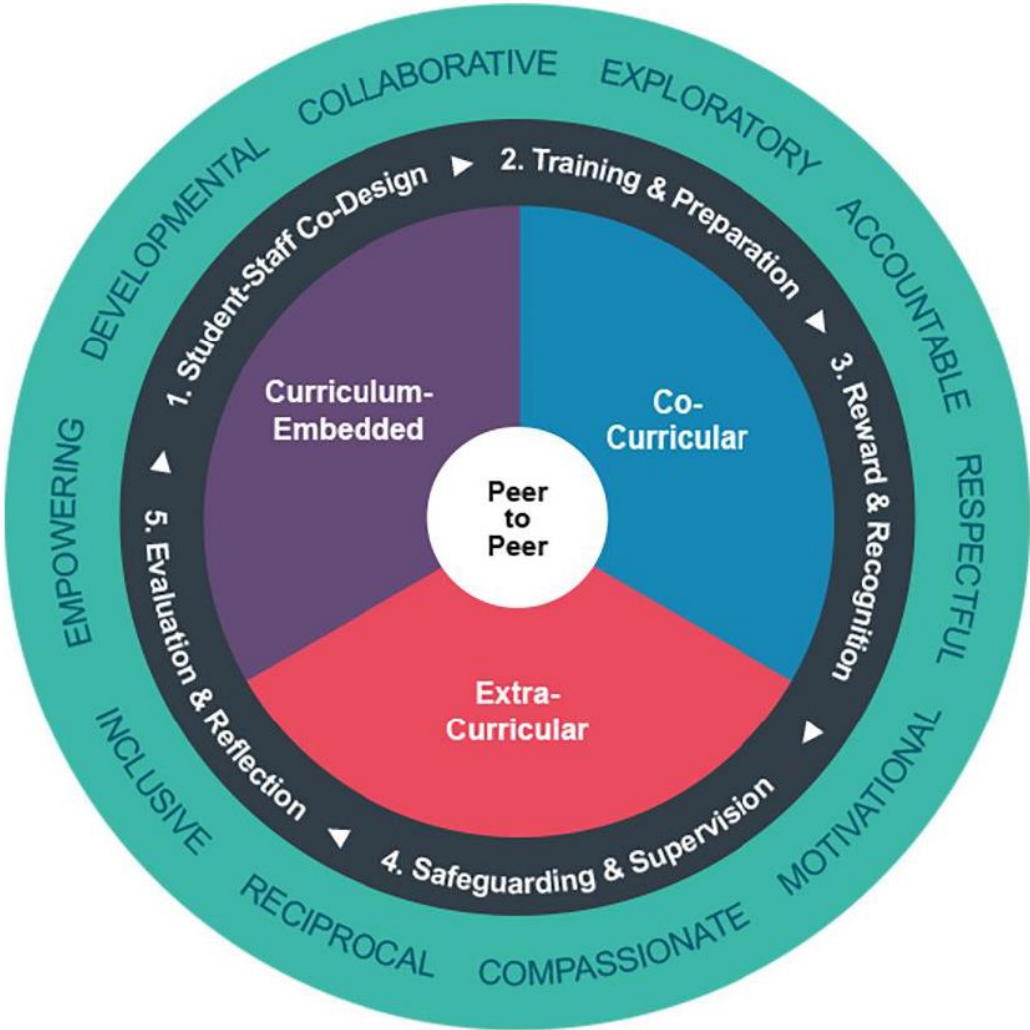


PAL-PASS network meeting

June 2026

- 1 - Introduction: What is peer support and how is it delivered?
- 2 - Highlights and discussion:
 - Theme 1: Attendance and engagement
 - Theme 2: Peer leaders and training
 - Theme 3: Establishing effective peer schemes
- 3 - Future direction of the network. Your thoughts.

What is peer-to-peer support?



Peer-to-peer framework: embedding peer leader & support in HE.
AdvanceHE, October 2025

Curriculum-Embedded	Co-Curricular	Extra-Curricular
- Group work - Problem-based learning - Peer-led team-based learning (PLTL) - Action Learning Sets - Peer Review/Crits - Peer Feedback and Assessment - Online/ asynchronous peer interaction	- Peer Assisted Study Sessions (PASS) - Peer Assisted Learning (PAL) - Peer mentoring - Peer coaching - Buddying - Academic Societies	- Student Union societies - Specialist peer communities - Student Ambassadors - Student Champions - Student Advisors - Student Partners - Course Reps - Residential/ Hall Reps

Table 1. Examples of peer-to-peer activities in different contexts of the student experience

How is it delivered in maths?

1 – Peer-led sessions

Peer Assisted Learning (PAL), Peer Mentoring, Peer Tutors, Peer Assisted Study Session (PASS), and the STEM Clinic.

Student-led

Available to: Mainly Y1

Size: 20 – 450 students

Academic support & community



1- or 2- hour sessions.

Run weekly.

Large schemes: 3-times/week.

Targeted: 3 – 4 times/semester

2 – Peer supported sessions

“Learning assistants” within *workshops/tutorials* run by lecturers

“Peer Leaders” within *problem solving* classes run by PhD students

3 – Peer social sessions

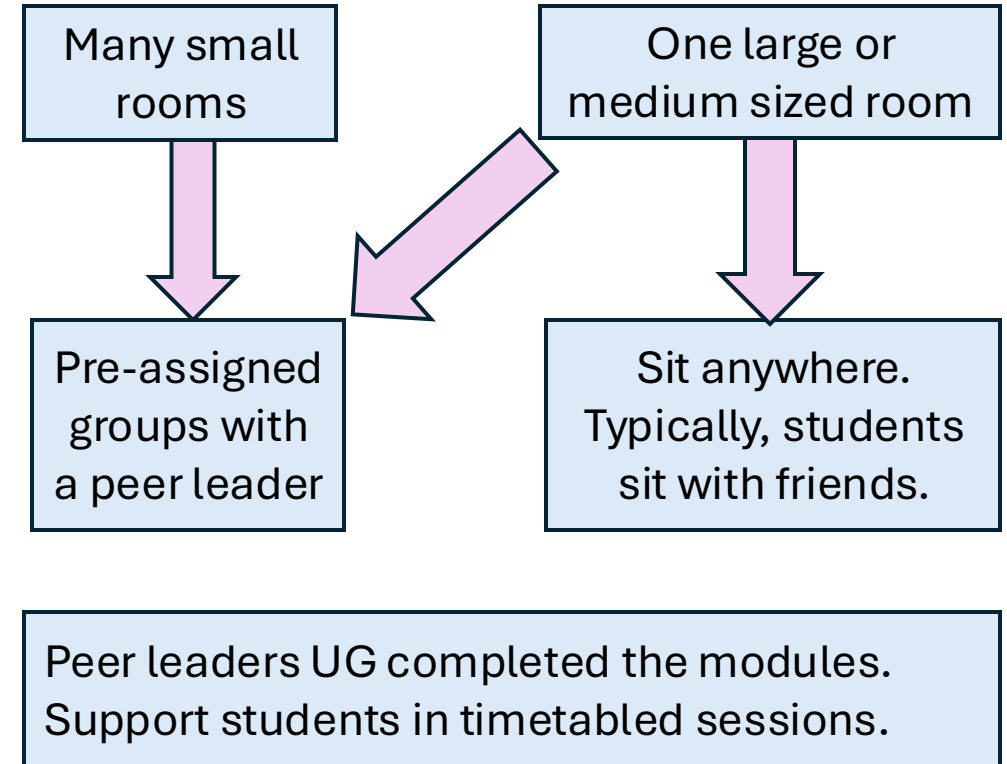
Maths Café



Focus on bringing students together (across year groups)

Mainly social space for community building

Academic peer support embedded



Theme 1: Attendance and engagement

Survey responses

- Low to moderate attendance/ engagement is most common
- Starts stronger (30-50%) and drops off (10-25%) during S1 and into S2
- Some see boosts near assessment deadlines
- Students tend to prioritise other things

Insights from maths academic leads

What most helps to <i>encourage student engagement</i> ?	
Advertise	Module VLE and lecturers' recommendation
	Peer support leaders – linked to social events
	Word of mouth within student community
Timetable	Having sessions in the timetable
	Good time slots and rooms
Purpose	Useful sessions - explaining content, problem solving, preparation for assessment
Peer leaders	Good peer leaders have better attendance.
	Mentors who make returning worthwhile

Theme 1: Attendance and engagement

Why do students not attend / disengage from peer support?

Social aspects

Some students find the **social aspect** of group study stressful

Embarrassment when other students in their group are discussing content they don't understand

Timetabling

Some students don't have classes on Wednesday's so **won't travel** to campus just for PAL

Timetabling is done by the central team; sessions are often **not in a 'good' time slot**

Sessions ends up in rooms on the other side of campus or in **unsuitable/ old rooms**.

Competing priorities

Some students fall behind with their studies and **don't know where to start**

Lot of competing demands on their time; supported study sessions have **low priority**

Problems with attendance are **not confined to problem classes** and are seen in lectures too.

Too busy with work or other commitments to attend optional extras.

Students get information about a wide variety of activities and they **struggle to prioritise**

Communication

Some students are **not good at monitoring emails** so miss important information

Not recognising its benefits, as they get lots of emails, social media posts, lecture shout outs

Some students were **confused** about what PASS is for

Lack of need

Completed Further Maths, so **don't feel they need to attend**

Some **prefer to study alone**

How important is attendance for your peer-support scheme?

What is the biggest factor influencing attendance and engagement at your institution, and what has been most effective in addressing it?

Theme 2: Peer Leaders & Training

Emerging themes from the survey

1. Good peer leaders are thought to be the most important factor for effective peer support
2. Peer leaders' sense of ownership of the scheme is important
3. We are asking a lot of our leaders
 - Tutor vs friend
 - Varied scheme aims
4. Group leaders experience common challenges
 - Group dynamics
 - Dealing with incorrect explanations



Our influence

1. What qualities make a good peer leader?
 - Confident
 - Approachable
 - Knowledgeable
 - Good communication skills
2. How do we support and develop strong peer leaders?
3. How can we facilitate leaders' sense of ownership?

Do you provide peer leader training at your institution,
if so, how does it work and to what extent does it
prepare them?

How can we facilitate leaders' sense of ownership of
the scheme and encourage them to develop skills?

Theme 3: Establishing effective peer schemes

Question: What factors contributing to *effective* peer-led sessions?

Categories	Themes	Where we influence this
Peer Leaders	Peer leaders who are:	Selection of peer leaders
	Personality: friendly and approachable	Incentives for peer leaders
	Attributes: confident	Training & mentoring of peer leaders
	Skills: good communicators, competent, knowledgeable	
Environment	Student-led sessions (no staff in the room)	Structuring schemes
	Supportive and informal environment	Timetabling influence
	Peer leaders building a rapport with students	
	Location of sessions (not on the other side of campus)	Promoting schemes
	Encouragement from Module Leaders	
Session content	Having something interesting for everyone to discuss	Working with peer leaders
	Links to assessment	Working with module leaders
	Show links to future modules	

What factors do you feel contribute to effective sessions and to what extent can you influence them?

Future direction of the network

1 - A place for maths leads (for peer-to-peer support) to come together for informal chats

↳ Get to know people. Share ideas. Get insights. Help improve our schemes.

↳ Online. Twice per year. Plus, ad hoc.

2 - A place to disseminate our work – focus on sharing practitioner advice

↳ PAL-PASS website with practical guides and resources

↳ Insights on initiatives in maths: context, putting into practice, benefits, challenges, advice for others.

↳ Resources: PAL-PASS training programs, samples questions used in PAL-PASS schemes, etc.

3 – A place for individual development

↳ Profession recognition: develop & evidence scholarship for Fellowship / Senior Fellowship

↳ Develop collaborative projects if this is your focus

↳ Career development: evidencing ‘external impact and esteem’

Your thoughts...?